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1928, The Awakening

There is a widespread belief that unlike mainstrem politicians like Gandhi, ‘these daring young men had no social ideology, no thought to guide their actions’[1] as Bipin Chandra has reminded us. Nothing could be further from the truth. The reality was that the ‘major commitment’ of the revolutionary movement ‘was to liberate India from foreign rule and to transform Indian society through a revolution.’[2] In fact, ‘the greatest advance’ that they made ‘was in the definition and development of their aims and objectives’. So that ‘the questions that they sought to answer’ were ‘What were the aims of their struggle against the foreigners?’ and ‘What sort of changes in society and polity were they aiming at.’ They asked the sort of questions that Gandhi never did, such as ‘What sort of social order and state structure would replace the present ones?’ And what is remarkable, but remains equally much forgotten to this day, is that ‘at the purely intellectual level, they succeeded . . .’[3] because they alone brought about a social awareness about the plight of the Indian people.

As an eighteen-year-old in 1928, when writing in Amritsar’s *Kirti* in his native Punjabi, Bhagat Singh was already aware that ‘when awareness spreads in the countries, the countries don’t sleep’ and that ‘after a few days, they rise with great enthusiasm and launch an attack’, which was why ‘today, Hindustan is energised once again. Hindustan is gaining strength again. India is awakening again’.[4] This is why, by the time of his first trial in 1929 before the Delhi Sessions Court, he is able to hail ‘the end of an era of Utopian non-violence, of whose futility the rising generation has been convinced beyond the shadow of doubt’.[5] From this, Moffat is led to observe how ‘there is a genuine sense in HSRA writings that the